

So why wait around when you can take advantage today? The Small Business Administration has implemented programs that have drastically changed the futures of the individuals and the companies that have qualified for them. You can qualify too.

There's the Small Business Innovation Research program, also known as the SBIR. In an effort to stimulate the forward-thinking aspects of qualifying small businesses, the SBIR offers a host of monetary awards, some totaling as much as \$100,000. Yes, you read that right: \$100,000.

For the last 25 years, the SBIR has been awarding all kinds of money to all kinds of small business owners! And you deserve to get in on the action too.

There are eleven agencies and federal governments who, each year, set aside funds to give away to people just like you! And it's simple. It's there for the taking. Once you check the site (www.sba.gov/SBIR/indexsbir-sttr.html) to make sure you meet all eligibility requirements, you're halfway there. Then it's on to putting together an excellent proposal that'll catch their attention.

When reviewing proposals, agencies look for small businesses that can demonstrate an exceptional degree of development and technical prowess. If a company can successfully exhibit these things, then it has a great chance of qualifying! If you meet all eligibility requirements, it's worth putting the time into applying. When we're talking about free money in amounts of up to \$100,000, you might as well give it a go!

The SBA Office of Technology also has the Small Business Technology Transfer Program (STTR). Five federal departments award \$2 billion to small high-tech businesses in this program. If that is your business and you have less than 500 employees, you can apply to get a piece of that \$2 billion pie. It's very exciting to learn that the Department of Energy, Department of Defense, Department of Health & Human Services, National Science Foundation, and NASA have a percentage of their R&D budget allocated for this program. The SBA is the coordinator between those that apply for the grants and these agencies. The dollars are big, the work is important; very heady stuff.

The Small Business Administration offers other great free money programs, and you can learn more about them here: www.sba.gov. I